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From the editor-in-chief

India, as we all know, is the home of *jugaad*. The best translation of that word is a combination of innovation and enterprise. It could be something as bizarre as using a washing machine to churn lassi or revolutionising rural transport by attaching a motorcycle engine to a flatbed cart and calling it a Maruta.

The combination of creativity and technology produces genuine innovation and a powerful tool that impacts the lives of millions of people and changes the way we can live. It is why for decades, despite all the hurdles and handicaps of the licence raj and its stifling quotas, India has kept going. *Jugaad* to Indians was both instinct and inspiration. The drive for a better way out after all, is in India's bloodstream.

Pre-liberalisation, this drive involved three factors. The first was substituting a lack of genuine imports, which is what Swaraj tractors achieved in the 1960s. The second was to use local resources, just like Amul made India's first milk powder with buffalo milk. The third was mass availability which was done by the pharma sector in using new manufacturing processes to make cheap medicines, which are still being bought in large quantities by overseas visitors to our country.

After India opened up its markets, a flood of innovation came naturally to many sectors. India is the country that gave birth to radical transport ideas, be it the electric car or the Nano. Our power shortages have led to the invention of a plastic inverter. It is as if Indian minds can always find ways to leap over our many stumbling blocks.

This when we spend only 0.8 per cent of our GDP on R&D according to the Department of Science and Technology's 2006 data, while it is 1.09 for China, 2.96 for South Korea and 3.09 for Japan. There are now institutions dedicated to the creative mind, like the National Innovation Foundation, an autonomous organisation established under the Department of Science and Technology, or the Technopreneur Promotion Programme, also launched by the Ministry of Science and Technology, that promote innovation, but in a country bursting with ideas these are far too few.

We decided to recognise Indian innovation and focused our eighth Spirit of India special on the thinkers who become drivers of change. Everywhere our correspondents went, they found India's common people with their uncommon deeds. Like Prajapati Mansukhlal Raghavji from a community of potters in Gujarat, who innovated refrigerators made of clay that are not only affordable but also work without electricity. Or Dr Aarti Kinikar who saved the lives of hundreds of children with her indigenous nasal bubble during the swine flue crisis in Pune last year. One young man has designed a jacket that can be used in extreme heat or cold while a group of IIT students have developed NETRA, an unmanned aerial vehicle that can travel for half an hour, covering 1.5 km with a camera providing live video feed.

As the special issue shows, innovation is not restricted to only those with access to education or technology. It is gender-neutral and class-unconscious. The Indians you meet in this Spirit of India special are living examples of Apple founder Steve Jobs' words: Innovation truly distinguishes between a leader and a follower.


(Aroon Purie)



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